The Indian tradition of the padyatra and its huge connection with people is well established. You have to be part of it to understand how it is unmatched in its capacity to connect with people at their own pace, understand their living realities, and communicate in a way that incorporates and transcends the barriers of different languages and cultures.

As a political platform for communication, the Bharat Jodo Yatra took advantage of all this, while surpassing a lot of what was thought to be the limit in terms of scale, outreach and openness. In a country facing a sharp restriction in democratic dialogue, the Yatra created and demonstrated the creative power of democratic space even as it moved along.

While the Yatra was a political one, led by a political party, its leadership made sure it was reaching out to other like-minded parties and civil society organizations, and soliciting the views of citizens across the country. The pace allowed genuine, long and spontaneous conversations to take place while walking, and during short breaks for food or rest—and as the padyatra became part of its surroundings. The more structured periodic interactions with special groups of people enabled the tabling and development of thought and conversations into more concrete policy formulations, and preparing the building blocks for necessary political change. Effective political thought and progressive change is contingent on consultation and dialogue with the most affected people. The pace of the padyatra allowed these conversations and dialogues to highlight and understand the main issues—framed and defined by the concerned or affected people. The same issue could then be discussed with a wide range of people who could be potentially involved or affected by the policy and its implementation. Most importantly, in a true demonstration of the power of ongoing democratic consultation, promises made were kept alive and followed up on immediately. In fact, some of the credibility of the Yatra was built on a more lasting and meaningful outcome on the concerns that were raised. This ongoing conversation and dialectic between discussion and action is critical to the relevance of what could eventually end up being a meaningful political initiative or breakthrough to deal with that particular concern.